

Part I:

if you eat your cigarette butts, no one will ever find
them

im looking at the fish, the fish is looking at me

There's a man at my bus stop
With glasses that make fishbowl eyes and
The nervousness of an amateur cop
Convinced authority is a disguise

He paces and checks the times
As if the 828 changes route daily
His windbreaker is striped with lime
I think he thinks he's failing

--

There's a kid at my bus stop
With a beaky nose and fascist hair and
They look tired enough to drop
And sleep on the dirty pavement there

They wear a leather coat
And think of themselves highly
Sometimes when I have nothing to worry about
I wonder what they think of me

Belated Goodbye

I woke up on Friday
And fell asleep on Sunday
Cramming the laundry hours
And psychedelic nights
Between them two

I spent my money on Friday
Bought
A grey knit scarf, a cabbie cap
A tie with flowers and a ring to match
At that little thrift store
For the friend who gave me this journal
Two Chinese lunches
Three alcoholic dinners
And a fine for sixty euros for forgetting
my train ticket

I wasted my life on Saturday
Too much to eat during
Seven hours of TV living
And I didn't say enough of a good bye
To my sister
Who left on Sunday
Who made the day feel more than purgatory

I stepped back into myself Sunday
Extricating from a sea of stressors
At three subpar breakfasts
Two hours apart
I showered off
40-hour old running sweat
And made plans to see someone I love
My sister got home at 10:30 here
And told us so when I was already asleep
Then?

I woke up on Monday
With no sleep in sight
Lying out future drowsy hours
And gunpowder nights

Fire-Eater

I am a fire-eater
A honey-swallower
I feast on all that is light and sweet
Then mourn when the world is hard and bitter

I am a downy glutton
A love-leaver
I devour all that is soft and kind
Then mourn when the world is dark and loveless

NEVER LIFTING UP THE PEN

WISH I'D LOST THE CAP
SO I COULD WRITE UNTIL DESERT HITS THE SPEARPOINT
NO BLOOD ONLY STONE BARREN IN PEACE
AND THE ROWS OF SOLDIERS TURN TO SLEEPING TULIP BULBS
BENEATH THE GROUND
PLEASE DON'T ASK ME WHEN THEY'LL
WAKE UP
WAKE UP
YOU'RE NOT ASLEEP BUT YOUR EYES R CLOSED
AND SO YOU CAN'T SEE THE BRAID JUST SPUN FOR YOU ON THE
BRIDGE OF YOUR NOSE TO MAKE YOU CROSS-EYED
ROLL THOSE MARBLES DOWN THE CHUTES
SEE NOW YOU ARE THE MARBLE
ROLLING ROLLING UNDER CLEAR SKY
AND YOU
CURL UP
CURL UP INSIDE THE GLASS TO FIND PEACE IN THE MIDDLE OF
THE HURRICANE
WHEN THE RAIN IS BEATING DOWN YOUR CHEEKS
AND THE WIND @ YOUR BACK IS BEGINNING TO SCREAM THE
KETTLE IS FINISHED
AND THE WATER IS BOILED
SO TAKE OUT THE TEA CUPS
& SIT ME DOWN
& SCALD MY THROAT
OR I MAY NEVER DRY OUT

Feb 19

I imagined myself washed away by a hypothermic shore,
Sunk to the bottom like buried treasure

My eyes would bulge out of their sockets
Great boiled eggs under the surf.
I'd be paler than I am now
Paler than ice
& my eyes would be looking,
more than that,
transfixed!
On the stars above forever.

Say that they are suspended high by little wires
In numb, unseeing sight

My nails are black
A fish lives in my mouth

Going Out

At night, busses sound silent
& humming
marine bumblebee
bioluminescent and
carrying scum --
including me!
In the day, busses
are wooden horse carts
jam-packed with foul
thought & breed --
including me!
Or serene Elysium
A murmur here
some thrum of music
there
& a lot of grimy
new souls full of
potential

Virginia Behind

On a gray day, my hands packed away my enchanted
objects.

The sweaters that feel like embraces
The lover-given mementos
The notebooks I sewed my heart into

The old soul and youthful body were at odds as I looked
onto the road
I neglected my aged wisdom and followed my child's
wanderlust.

In my mind, I imagined serendipitous travels
Stumbling into luck and love.

I stumbled indeed
Into hard luck and rough love.

The curb is hard beneath my old body
My soul has caught up with the rest of me
I breathe in dust and cling to
Each worn memory of the past

Surrounded by people and totally alone.
I am too tired to go on
And too afraid to go home.

in leaving

In leaving, you notice unnoticeable things
And cherish them with obligation
Maybe in the coming months, you won't *miss*
The streets, the people, the places
But you'll think of them now

In leaving, you feel the air much heavier around you
And realize you'll never taste it again
For the moment, the humidity is a good thing
Because it trademarks this epoch
And leaves a damp trail in your memories

In leaving, you displace yourself from experiences
And know the hotel room, the car trips, the moving van
As mere flashes of grey, dull purgatory
The inbetween between you
And the place you're going.

a haughty poem about masochism

That all my one-only loves
(Defined by unrelenting sadness
To follow fortnight of madness)
Have been Pythons and Whips
On my bone-knuckled grip;
Those many dark and fair
In Heart too evil, black and bare
In Soul twisted by a bloodied Lace
Drawn to me, in kind of taste

Dulcet-still, the figure of Life
Stands on pli   with a steely knife
Cruelest of all my lovers Razed-Dear
I die on knees to her year after year
To face myself blind to stings, Hail and Sleet
From She who made bruising so Blessedly Sweet

this is shitty and rude to those who love you

To be fair,
Two both broke my heart
Chewed up and spit out my art
No--
Make that three who did the same
I can't say no to a pretty gay dame

And one of them is just, well
Not quite an angel who fell
Still selfish, full of ids and egos
Yet so unlike my old lover-crows

I can't hate him, either
The one with a head full of ether
The fingers on the projector wheel
Barely scraping what it is to feel

To be fair,
I can't hate any of them at all
And preferring their rainfall
To the storm of alone
I've built a summer home

Talking and Drinking Among the Motes

Kazoo noses buzzing, humming at every *out*
Snarling, snoring, snail snot at every *in*
I don't mean sleep, I mean all that talking LOUD!
We breathe out our whistles and whiniest thoughts, all
thin
We breathe the worst of the worst of the crowds
Can you call despair and dreadful dullness the
unholiest of sins?
What did Bradbury say?
I'm not asking, I know:
"The mind drinks less."
We compensate for not quaffing more
Life's finest wines and liquors best
By drinking the stale swill of the poor
Sipping the dust from beneath the mess
And too much of it
It's like the spaces in between the thrumming,
Moving bodies at the house party
The one that you couldn't think or feel or be in
It's all noise to fill the gaps around you and me
Hops to help the thirst that only send your mind
running
Static, plastic, all faux and ersatz claiming to bleed
You were pushing past sweaty bodies and wondering how
they had it figured out
But somehow, you didn't, even though you've always been
told, you're smart, they're not
And you were lost
But you felt better once you left
In morality and in the pink on your cheeks
Little did you know that when you got home again
And you were safe and cozy in your warm burrow of a bed
When the dust of the moonlight
Filters into your window and the stale beer is still on
your tongue
You'll still feel lost
And when you tip your head to your pillow
And hum yourself to sleep
You'll still be thirsty.

Writing on my Hands

I'm writing on my hands
Cos I have no paper
I'm wishing for strange lands
And many distant acres

I got up thinking
Of a new, strange day
But what I've been drinking
Makes the morn' old and grey

Maybe it's not the liquor
But the fact that I'm dying

Makes life all the quicker
When I spend my nights crying

Hey, so, I'm living in my head
And writing on my hands
Eyes down-sad
'Stead of up-dread

Give me bloody bands
Give me poison sands

Give me sick things,
All those big and smaller
Whatever emotions it brings
So long as it's some colour

Use the best of your paints
Make me take a stand
If not, I turn grey and faint
And go writing on my hands

Afraid

It is the world-whirling flip
Over bike and asphalt black
And the child that ran on glass
Is now tiptoeing over cracks

A vase is only breakable
Once you see it breaking
And life is only fleeting
Once you see it taken

I once became a stone
And dropped down a water-fall
Now into each cool pond
I dip a toe, that's all

I loathe a life too tame
Until my head on coffin laid
But I cannot yet grow wild
For I am so afraid.

Poetry, Misc.

I like to be scared sometimes
My heart gets a start
When I'm running up stairs in the dark,

And I like it when the spark; the light
Goes out and I scramble
At the door's heart for the handle

It's the thrill, in part, of fear
And also a faint hope
Of monsters-like-art to steal my final croak

If you fall for me, fall for terror
And shaking like leaves
For no reason at all than to later better breathe
--

Shoot heck darn
My head is made of yarn
Shit hell damn
I'll write something if I can
--

Gin rummy
Wet socks
Large nostrils
Cards splayed out like fingers
Beaches with white fossils
Periwinkles
Gummi bears
The rippling muscles beneath an animal's fur
Skulls
White bone sticking through skin
Earthquakes
Wrinkles
Brassy instruments
Businessmen's footsteps
Rhapsody
Pink tongues and dull teeth
Birch wood
Swelling of the heart
Running to the top of a hill and not being tired
Wooden mallets
Silk streamers
Sunlight lighting

Screaming bloody murder
Lattices
Heavy boxes making noise on hollow floors
Church bells ringing
On his merry way

I'm Alive

I'm Alive
I have breath in my lungs
I used to want to climb the rungs
Of the social ladder
And got bad and badder
Trying to be what I'm not
I had to give up a lot

I wrote that drunk
Or at least after drinking
Who'd have thunk
That'd be my time for thinking
I might've been with other kids
Bubbling beneath my lid
But I felt so all alone
Which has always been my home

Waving at the train station fences
Focus came to my lenses
The world doubled, became one
And if I didn't wobble, I'd run

I'd spent so much time living in my head
Suddenly I cared whether or not I bled
Someone said she liked I didn't care
Whether I got applause or glares
And that I could be alone
And still feel like I'm home

So goodbye to syzygy
Goodbye to chivalry
And love-sick animosity

The ladder is fallen, no more to climb
Gone is the Moon who loved my rhymes
And the kids who were there to share in my liquor
Are my friends, but leaving, quick and quicker

So yes, I'm alone, under moonlit squares
And yes, my heart, she has many tears
But I have breath in my lungs and beer on my tongue
And I don't mind being alone, because it's my home.

Death is Mandatory but not Encouraged

Interlude I
Daily Routine

Daily Routine

Beginning the slowday ritual
By making bitterfoot strides
Through the snowday nuptials
Of flurries and their asphalt brides

At midday, ceremony rises
Tangled branches that won't come undone
Too many walk upset by signs that
Every living thing has someone

A sundial click, the sun low
Tracing back intimate footsteps home
The sidewalk's divorcee flows
In the gutters, now alone

In the evening held by moon
All the walks more solitary
Nonexistent are natural grooms
So forget the lonely and unordinary

Part II:
unregulated post-coital massacres

Turntable Apology

Curse your citrine dramatics
So iconic; no more than a tune
Imagined, not listened
Returns me to our doublemint love
Glowing tasteless with the days a doro
Diamonds and pops faded by weeks
I chewed in nicotine tinted jaws that I
Felt nothing for you how you felt it for me

To be an angelic face, young cherubin staring up in
first snowfall
Means no obligation to the snow
To worship the serenity of an immovable stone, to
imitate and exalt the movement of ever-moving rains
Flatters none to nature;
Pyromaniac spouse trying with red eyes to stoke the ego
none so inflammatory:
I told you above the Rhine, swore to its Sirens, the
mind is too broken to keep you as mine

Isabella, am I Heathcliff?
Have you persisted to learn me and my wintery
indifferences?
Now to think of me
Vinegar to the tongue, ice to the spine; churn in the
stomach, strain to the heart
And cruel was I to offer you a reprieve of snowy
embrace
Nip the tops of your Impish ears, whip the tails of
your artist's peacoat
Yet not so cruel
Even in my mad and irascible envy
To tell you how I think of you
With a coming tune
Always imagined; never listened

Palinopsia

I am sick with this sight enchanted
Those rosy features ardently accrued
Seem to eternally remain
Star of mine, though you've gone
I can't keep from seeing you

Romantic Things to Say

I hope you die in my arms
You weep like clouds in spring
No one else may do you harm
I can hear your red blood sing
Your bones are lily white
I want to breathe your air
Your screams ring clear and bright
Your flesh is better bare
I want to watch you get old
And one day decompose
I'll do exactly as I'm told
If you'll be my bleeding rose
You truly make me want to die
For you, my deathlong wife
Though agony to say goodbye
If you say no, I can't keep you alive

Risky Words

Risky words thought over too long
Said despite what could go wrong
It's plunging into waters murky
Where any danger could be lurking
Yet worth it, in a small, strange way
To know that I could make your day
We exchange fear and trepidation
And the chance of love's damnation
For the barest glimmer of heartlight
To the dark pool bring a speck of bright
In pursuit of that earth slightly sunlit
Every worry is surely worth it

I write about being poisoned

I say I have been poisoned
By the drugs of the blonde
And how the brunette's liquor destroys and
Has bound me to my wrongs

To save me is no institution
No sympathetic sinners' ears
And waters of pure ablution
To wash me of nicotine and beer

Into my pages must my pen dip
My poor, gouged life in hieroglyphs

Is prose better than a five year chip?
When did despondency
And murky self-pity
Become my only lift?

Mercy on my victim's heart
Mercy on my poisoned blood
To find passion in everything is art
Yet chasing my flame always lands me in mud

Perpendicular

The trouble with me is that I fall for everyone

Does that make me stupid
Or just in love with the world
And all it contains?

I sit on the bus and I fall for
A young woman sitting across from me
She has sweet, distant eyes
And patterns on her skirt
I want to ask her where she's going
What she wants out of life
And who she is
But then she's gone.

I look out the window and I fall for
Two people running in absolute synchronicity
They look like one long person
With their pumping calves
Falling step by step
I want to ask why they're running
How they know each other
But then we're passed.

I settle down in a booth and I fall for
The server who brings me my menu
He seems delighted to have me
Impossibly warm
I want to ask him why he works here
Why he's happy
And if it's sincere or not
But instead, I leave a heavy tip.

I love and hate people-watching
Because I crave those people's stories
I want to talk to every one of them
Learn them, know what puts light in their eyes
But they walk by or I have to go

Perpendicular, we meet once and never again

Interlude II:
Inside the Seasons

Inside the Seasons

dayshine glowlife
insects on the floor
we kiss the rain of pastel blue
and think of how to mourn

gentle-sun greenblood
passion in the sky
running sooths across the plain
and a tender sherbert sigh

spice-earth wildnight
apple of the moon
amber ghosts walk on the lake
and the pheasants learn to groom

deadplace stickbreath
frosted bluebell days
the waters are all mirrors now
and we love the sun's sick rays

deadearth greenlife
we begin anew
seasons come and pass plusloved
for all they truly grew

Part III:
image edited for aesthetic

Virginian Villanelle

Suburban NOVA, peppermint green
Schools full of sharp pencil bores
And my eyes no brighter than a new sun beam

Sneaking out at night mid-dream
Revelling in neon convenience stores
Walking home to Gasoline

That dark haired girl with the eyes so mean
Who could turn praise from a word like whore
Who didn't want you, but a Byronic James Dean

The aquiline nose who wasn't what he seemed
Who made self-discovery a sick, brutal chore
With his sandy eye slusty and body greedy lean

Living for weeks as a fractured team
Boxes and my mattress laid out on the floor
One housewife, one ghost, and two dreary teens

I think of Virginia and all that's been
And the parts of me she tore
And though I speak with a rosy sheen
I'm grateful we don't live there anymore

well bound reflections

My drunk father said when it thundered
That's the devil beating his wife
I thought of it as our love went under
And we fought within inches of our lives

I left home that night and planned
To stand at the station
With my suitcase in hand
And find a faraway occupation
Somewhere the girls are gentle
The sun ever-present and fine
And to that idea all men fall
I wanted to forget you'd been mine

On the way far from church bells
In the thick of the night
I stumbled on an old well
And fell like the drunk in the barfight

My back broke like the glass
I shattered on our kitchen floor
Paralyzed and fallen, the sordid past
Chased me and, despite the breaks, hurt more

I wailed, a creature writhing in hell
Screaming out for you to come down
Through the night and to the well
And bring me back to solid grand
I feared you might trip too
Or insist I finish our lover's fling
But as the pain and sorrow grew
I remained a loud and pitiful thing

The sun rose to my unshallow grave
And only then, my fate its most poor
I quieted to think of all you gave
And died silent
Not your problem anymore

Said in Foggy Breath

There a many who say Winter is bleak
When the sun is dead and the sky is weak
It's corpses, they say, corpses and ashes
And each drop of rain is lash after lashes

I go out with you, in dark, in coats
To see this dead world on which we float
And saw instead so much pure and clearer
Upon each flat surface, in ice, was a mirror

We went down the streets cars dare not go
For each mountain upon mountain of glistening snow
And we looked into Glass from highest peak
With the hopes our faces the ice would keep

With the coming of day, our night was done
Sorrow-filled bodies turned home to run
But as I turned, I saw the ice hold
Your face
With cheeks turned sunset pink by cold

Man in the Moon/Watcher of the Streets/Hands on the Railing Man

Man in the Moon,
He was born poor but grew up richly
Dipping his fingers
Into whatever passed

Watcher of the Streets,
He likes creases
And neat stacks of paper
And combs every strand of hair away from his face

Hands on the Railing Man
He was born parched but grew up quaffing
Dipping his
Near skeletal fingers
Into the swollen cauldron of life

Man in the Moon
Looking down at ants on asphalt
He likes creased jackets
And the slippery marble edge
Of perfect stacks of paper

Watcher of the Streets
Faceless and precise
And sharp in the wrong places
Like his heart and his eyes

The Brain Digger

The Brain Digger, he comes at night
With needle fingers as his sight
He scales the bricks, licks the sticks in his lips
And crosses the room on cricket legs

The Brain Digger, he loves your eyes
And slides his needles beneath their rise
He searches for what makes your being
Your thoughts your dreams
Your every feeling

And once he takes them, you will find
A newfound love for black and white
That replaces a love for anything bright
Worse still if it wasn't you
It could've been anyone else you knew

Grip the stones of unjust walls
Pour your heart with more and all
Doesn't matter, if you hear the call
Of needle eye fingers high and raw
For it's night, and approaching?
The Brain Digger

A Young Woman on a Beach, Thinking About Death

White-blooded nerve endings
On cerulean Erns ascending
A rise of two kinds of gold;
White beads and silken rolls
Mirroring gems of consenture
Bordered by blue bent firs
Black petals pursed in valley
& pensive with finale

On the Zenith of Our Love

On the Zenith of Our Love?
Better to find silk in the roughs
Than to manifest a wingless dove
Doomed to drown in heartless bluffs
Pledge and vow I'll duly sew
To wait upon and worship You
For You are one of intensely few
With whom I'd miss the morning dew
My lips will run ragged on wire
Moulding slowly a virtued liar
Still, for my heart so dire
We are bound to woodless fire
And a marble floor cruelly scoured
A reminder through each alien hour
For all our aching heart and power
You are a mute and I, a coward

it's about pornography.-- or any kind of loveless sex

We see them jog from beyond grated fray
Well-oiled bones in an ersatz array
The gear locks taut into the wheel
Arachnid apparati reach to feel
Bolts of steel and each ball-bearing
They are unsuccessful without once erring
Vane ruptures, innards power each sump and jaw
Up and down to work the hydraulic claw
Were they music, they would have no tune
Little more than a loveless interlude.

**remember that time I climbed a mountain and thought it
was deep**

Sunset climb on a mountain
To look out
Above grass and land
And crooked bouts
Funny--
The night sky *isn't* black
It's blue and brown and
With clouds? lacks!
Oh, but
Below the elbowed range
Towns in darkness drink the change
And pour it out with orange-yellow-all
To bring again *small*
And earthling *sighs*

Who is small only due to the sky?
What the world has cleverly done
Is give us nothingness and therein,
Freedom.

Eudaimonia

Eudaimonia
Spectre of wind-whipped telos
Askesis and Ammonia
The fondest path to Hades throes
Marble is palest besides the stone
And loses its luster alongside bone
Eudaimonia
Platonic and erratic venal nebulae
Self-loathing euthanasia
To face the void with maelstrom sway
The Forms come to the dialectic
Altogether ignore a scattered Eclectic
Eudaimonia

Words of War

Bodies twisted and contorted
In a splendid display of rigor mortis
Their mouths are open towards the sun
As though their final breath said *run*
Bones albicant and marrow
White flesh made red by lead-lined arrow
Smoke curling towards the sky
And a wailing widow asking *why*
Two blackened figures touch by chance
One free-willed, the other forced to advance
Suicide and murder, the two of them and more
For there truly are no winners
Nor true salience in war.

Falls Church Skyline

It was late at night
And I was walking home
Over dew-stricken sidewalks and under a cloudy sky.
My coat, swathed around me
Brushed my skin with a felten touch
And warmed my abdomen in the chilled, damp air.
The sound of my feet,
Slapping the concrete with hard-soled boots,
Filled the night in a satisfactory way.
I am the singular being now, awake and alone.
I make the noises, effortlessly hold the approaching
morning at a distance
And blaze my trail through suburbia.
There is the taste of bitters in my mouth,
The scent of rain in my nose,
And as I look up, there are stars above my head.
The clouds, turned lilac by the moonlight,
Have parted to reveal that soft, pale cheek
Of the Moon, and the paint-splattered white of the
stars against the black tar sky.
I still, the clear surface of my eyes reflecting such a
sight
And I swear I could hear wind chimes.
On that great expanse, among the fixtures, slides one
white bead.
My lips part,
Awe at that shimmering ice-skater
Skimming the horizon.
Fog leaves my mouth,
A nebulous cloud,
And the inside of my mouth is scraped by cold.
And yet no amount of frozen claws
Running their edges along me could part my gaze
From that gymnast on the ethereal trapeze, that sinking
diamond.
It drops behind a distant house,
Tumbling out of view.
I've been standing here for too long
My feet are frozen,
And when I bring my gloves up to my nose I sniff loudly
It feels as if it has disturbed the night more than my
quickenings footsteps.
Resting back in warm sheets,

My head cratering the surface of my pillow,
Menthol now on my tongue, I look up at the ceiling.
Linen smell compares not to the twinkling night,
But staring at the paint above
And closing my eyes, I can still see that falling star.

Final Note

Final Note

Sit like a rock in a pond
Peer between the foggy fronds
Fine peace-- we have forever
In these leaves and this river
The world flowering over and
The dance of waterbound clover
We writers so slate stone and grey
Come to serenity and simply lay
Sit like a wireframe rocker on a porch
Watch the lights
Those golden-touched torches
Find peace-- we have forever
To meander between mauve and clever
Take a perch, take up your pen
We'll be stones-in-water,
Eternally hidden